Ethnic Identity: Narrative Differences of Blacks, Africans and Multiethnic Emerging Adults

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ABSTRACT

Much of the existing research on ethnic identity formation in emerging adults fails to adequately distinguish amongst two distinct groups; African Americans, whose ancestral heritage comes from the forced migration of people from Africa to work as slaves, and Africans, those who recently immigrated to America from continental Africa on a voluntary basis. This research study focuses on 23 emerging adults who agreed to share a narrative account of a time when they personally became aware of their ethnicity. Participants were University of Minnesota undergraduate students who were self-identified as either: (1) African, (2) Black/African American, or (3) Multiethnic. Participants' narratives did not differ significantly based on their group membership, but results were consistent with previous research for each group. Implications for further research on identity development is discussed.

BACKGROUND

- **What is Ethnic Identity?**
  - The focus of this study is *ethnicity* as an identifier of personal identity. The ethnicity category includes three identifiers: (1) culture, (2) personal identity, (3) minority group status (Phinney, 1996).
- **Why use a narrative approach?**
  - Narratives are personal memories of an individuals experience that allows them to make sense of their life in a particular point in time, thus connecting it to their life story and identity formation (Thorne, 2001).
- **Why these three ethnic groups?**
  - Multiethnic, African and African American groups have different histories and different cultural and ethnic values. They are separate ethnic groups but are always grouped together, not allowing for adequate comparison.
- **What are the categories used to code the narratives?**

Theme	Percentage
Experience of Prejudice	52.18%
Awareness of Underrepresentation	17.39%
Awareness of Difference	30.43%
Connection of Culture	0%
Total	100%

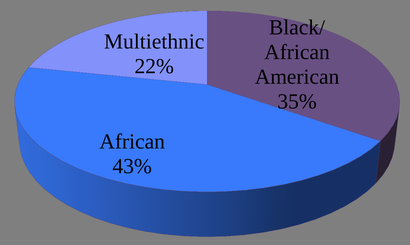
RESEARCH QUESTIONSAND HYPOTHESIS

- **Are there group differences between self-identified African American Blacks, Africans and Multiethnic group members regarding the themes of the narratives told of a time when they became fully aware of their ethnicity?**
  - Hypothesis: There are differences amongst the three groups regarding the narrative themes.

METHODS

- **Participants:** 23 college students at the University in Minnesota participated, ranging in ages 17-28.

Distribution of Ethnic Groups



- **Survey:** Participants were given a survey entitled "Ethnicity in Everyday Experiences." The research question only called for examination of the questions: "What racial/ethnic groups do you identify with being a member of?" and "Please describe [the] event [of when you became aware of your ethnicity] in detail."
- **Analysis:** A chi-squared test of independence was used to analyze the four narrative themes and the three categories of ethnicity.

NARRATIVES

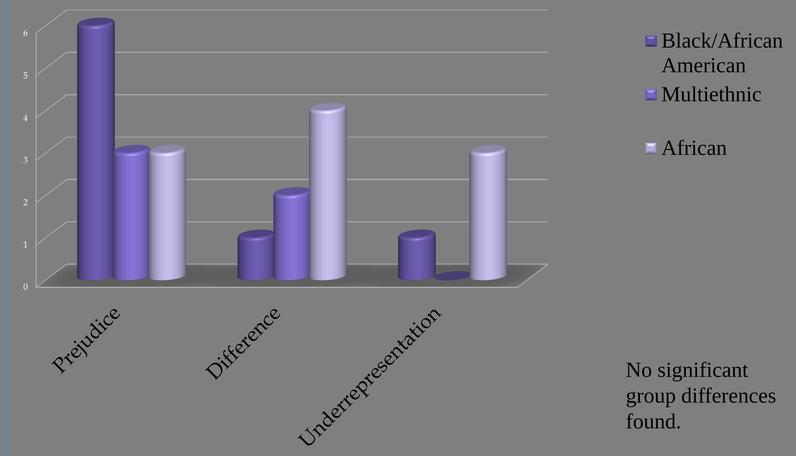
- **Multiethnic, Experience of Prejudice**
  "I was playing with my friends in elementary and it was a diverse group. However, I was the only person of African descent and they were making jokes about Africans. I recently came to America so I was unfamiliar with the crude humor that was associated with the jokes. The phrase "African booty-scratcher" was continuously said towards me and that's when I fully realized that I was different then them."

- **Black/African American, Awareness of Difference**
  "I was at the Awkward Dance. The dance was awkward because people wear abnormal clothes and do crazy dances. I was having a great time, but it started to get really hot. I knew from experience that when it gets hot, I would sweat my hair out. I don't get perms and my hair is really thick so when my hair finally sweated out, it look really course and bushy. Then, to make matters worse, this guy came up to me and tried to put a comb through my hair. He did it twice. I covered my head as soon as I could. I wished at that moment that had the texture of my grandfather's hair (curly) or white women hair. I still feel the pain I felt when it happened, but there is nothing I can do about it. Unless I get a perm or wear some weave, my hair will always be this way. All I can do is accept it. I felt sad and embarrassed."

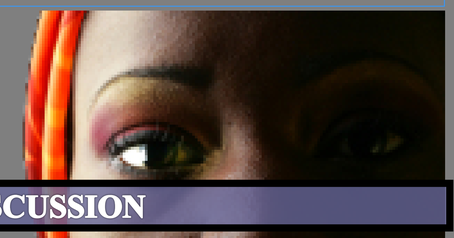
- **African, Awareness of Underrepresentation**
  "This was my first day of school in the U.S. I come from Nigeria where everyone is considered 'black.' I had never seen so many Caucasians before."

RESULTS

Frequency of Themes Based on Racial Group



No significant group differences found.



DISCUSSION

- The African group is distributed quite evenly through the categories (i.e., Awareness of Underrepresentation (AU), 3; Awareness of Difference (AD), 4; Experience of Prejudice (EP), 3).
- The Black/African American group had the majority of the narratives in the Experience of Prejudice theme (AU, 1; AD, 1; EP, 6).
- The Multiethnic group had no instances of Awareness of Underrepresentation and were evenly distributed in the remaining categories (AU, 0; AD, 2; EP, 3).

Findings were generally consistent with previous work.

- Syed, Juang & Azmitia (2011) had also found a high amount of Experience of Prejudice accounts in the African American samples from other universities outside of the U of M.
- Rong & Fitchett (2008) found that migrating to a society where social difference is based on race and not status could lead many Africans to identify narratives where Awareness of Underrepresentation and Awareness of Difference are the themes.
- Syed, Azmitia (2008) found persons from multiethnic backgrounds had no instances of narratives fitting the theme of Awareness of Underrepresentation, suggesting that persons from this group may be used to situations in which no one looks exactly like them, thus making the experience non-memorable.

- **Limitations:**
  - Small sample size used for analysis
  - Subjectivity of the term "Black" can take for referring to group membership
- **Further Research:** Further examination and comparison at different stages in identity development, and at different universities around the country and world

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